

Dear Doctor,

We are currently recruiting participants diagnosed with major depressive disorder to take part in the MicroDep-01 study, **a randomised, placebo controlled and double-blind study assessing the safety, feasibility, and efficacy of low-dose psilocybin**. We seek your assistance in identifying potential participants.

Psilocybin is a naturally occurring compound found in a variety of psychedelic fungi often referred to as “magic mushrooms”. Emerging evidence suggests that psilocybin can be an effective and long-lasting treatment for depression. Microdosing refers to the practice of regularly consuming sub-hallucinogenic doses of psychedelic substances (for psilocybin, typically 1.5 – 5mg). **At this dose individuals do not experience significant alterations to their state of consciousness. Some individuals do not notice any subjective effects at all.** Some notice minor changes in emotions, attention, and perception. Individuals typically report being able to continue with their regular day to day activities following a microdose. **Studies show compelling evidence that administration of psychedelics in the microdose range can impact cognition in ways that are likely to have clinical benefits, in particular improved mood and reductions in depressive symptoms.** With the MicroDep Trial we hope to add to this scientific literature by investigating the safety, feasibility, and efficacy of low-dose psilocybin in treating moderate severity depression.

All participants in the trial will undergo thorough screening by a psychiatrist, and if deemed eligible, will be enrolled in a six-week intervention, consisting of 11 dosing sessions. Participants in the active drug condition will receive 4mg of synthetic psilocybin and will be monitored following each dose by a psychiatrist. There is the option to titrate the dose down if necessary. After the main intervention phase of the project is complete, participants in the placebo condition will be given the option to access the active drug intervention in an open-label extension if there is evidence of clinical efficacy.

To be eligible for the study, participants must meet the following criteria:

- Participant has a clinician's diagnosis of major depressive disorder.
- Participant meets the definition of moderate severity depression, defined as a score between 15 and 23 on the GRID Hamilton Rating Scale for Depression*
- Depression must be the primary diagnosis. Participants with other, more severe, co-morbid mental illnesses will not be eligible.
- Participant must not have used any antidepressant or antipsychotic medication in the prior 3 months.
- Participant must not have used any other psychotropic medication or drugs in the prior month (excluding alcohol, nicotine, caffeine and medications being used for long-term treatment of ADHD).
- Participant is aged 18+.
- Participant is fluent in English.
- Participant has not experienced moderate or severe suicidal ideation in the previous 12 months.
- Participant has no history of psychosis, bipolar disorder, stroke or epilepsy.
- Participant must not have a first degree relative with psychotic disorder.
- Participant must live within 40 minutes drive of Macquarie University (we will provide transport for all trial visits)

If you believe you have a patient that might be suitable for such a trial, please either refer them to us via the contact details below or inform them of the trial for them to contact us if they wish. While a doctor's referral is not necessary to participate in the trial, we will ask potential participants for the details of their regular treating clinician.

We would like to emphasise that we can only accept **unmedicated individuals with moderate levels of depression, without any more severe comorbid diagnoses**. If you have any questions, please get in touch, we are very happy to provide additional information. We can also organise a practice visit if that would be helpful. Thank you for your consideration of this trial.

To make a referral or enquiry, or to request trial information, background research or literature, contact:

Web: goto.mq.edu.au/microdep

Email: microdep@mq.edu.au

Phone: (02) 7230 1367 / Fax: (02) 9850 5747

We look forward to working with you and thank you for your assistance.

Sincerely,



Dr Vince Polito
Principal Investigator, MicroDep Trial

** We are NOT asking referrers to make a formal assessment of depression severity. You can refer patients you judge likely to meet this criterion.*

Resources

Systematic review of psilocybin research:

van Amsterdam, J., & van den Brink, W. (2022). The therapeutic potential of psilocybin: A systematic review. *Expert Opinion on Drug Safety*, 0(0), 1–8.

<https://doi.org/10.1080/14740338.2022.2047929>

Systematic review of microdosing research:

Polito, V., & Liknaitzky, P. (2022). The emerging science of microdosing: A systematic review of research on low dose psychedelics (1955-2021) and recommendations for the field. *Neuroscience & Biobehavioral Reviews*, 139, 104706.

<https://doi.org/10.1016/j.neubiorev.2022.104706>